



thrive in the competitive international market? Experts say it's unlikely to be a smooth ride with Air India also augmenting capacity, services and connectivity in the international sector. Then there are foreign carriers eyeing a bigger pie of the Indian market.

Rahul Bhatia, Promoter and Managing Director, IndiGo, says if you have cost leadership and can keep reducing costs, you can stimulate demand, fill planes and then order new planes; and that cycle goes on. "If you offer people air transportation at the right price point, they will move. If we move just 1% people travelling by train to planes, that will be a very large number. Just think of the number of aircraft you will need in India," he says.

GO GLOBAL STRATEGY

IndiGo's international growth started after the airspace re-opened post-Co-vi-d. The airline executed a major international expansion in 2024, launching 24 new/resumed international routes with 292 weekly flights. A vast domestic network, lower costs and a growing fleet can help IndiGo offer affordable travel, especially for price-sensitive first-time flyers from non-metros. It has emerged as the world's second fastest-growing airline after Qatar Airways in terms of seat capacity, which increased 10.1% in 2024, according to OAG. It has placed one of the world's largest orders for 932 aircraft.

India's international aviation market has three segments—regional international, to Middle East and Southeast Asia; mid-haul, covering parts of Europe, Africa; and long and ultra-long haul, to US, Canada, Australia and Japan. IndiGo already has a vast network in regional international. Air India operates to 42 destinations in 31 countries, including the US, the UK, Canada, Europe, Asia, Africa and Australia. The US is a key market for the airline. It operates 34 weekly flights to various cities in the US.

IndiGo will focus on London, Paris, Frankfurt, Spain and Italy to the west and Japan, Vietnam, Thailand and Singapore to the east, say analysts. They also expect a deeper foray into Africa, as Air India no longer operates to major destinations there, barring Nairobi. "IndiGo is the gold standard for low-cost platforms. The introduction of the premium class on international at a significant discount to traditional business class will stand



10%

**RISE IN
INDIGO'S
SEAT
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IN 2024**

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them in good stead," says Sanjay Lazar, CEO, Avialaz Consultants. He says IndiGo has monopolised almost 70% routes in Tier II/III cities. This will make it easier for it to connect domestic and international routes.

The airline's network map shows extensive coverage of South Asia, Southeast Asia and the Middle East, with notable connectivity from multiple Indian cities. In 2024, it launched 92 direct international flights from Bengaluru, followed by 42 from Chennai. Bengaluru was connected to Mauritius, Langkawi, Jeddah, Bali; Chennai to Penang; and Hyderabad to Male, Colombo and Abu Dhabi. The airline is also using capacity from non-metros cities—Bhubaneswar to Singapore, Bang-